New York Regional Mormon Singles Halloween Dance

By Elna Baker

*(hum or sing "Party in the USA" by Miley Cyrus *)*

ELNA: (Pg 12) *(stuffing a cookie in her mouth)* [Welcome to the] New York Regional Mormon Singles Halloween Dance. That's right -- it's a Halloween dance for all the single Mormons between the ages of 18 and 30 who live in the tristate area. That's a lot of virgins in one room. And I'm one of them.

Tonight I'm dressed like a Queen Bee. The best part of my costume is my stinger. I bought a black funnel from the hardware store and stuck it on my butt. *(turn and wiggle)* Genius! I was certain that some Mormon guy was going to see me and fall head over heels in love. I joked to my friends that the Queen Bee was going to find a drone. Instead, I'm by myself at the punch bowl stocking up on Oreo cookies. When I'm wrong, I'm wrong and strong.

The worst part is, I should've known better. This is my 4th New York Regional Mormon Singles Halloween Dance in a row -- a lame dance held in a church gym. Every year, I come hoping to meet "The One." And every year, I leave by myself, vowing never to come again. But by the time 365 days have passed, I've completely forgotten this commitment. In the end, I am here for one reason and one reason only: I want very much to fall in love.

INTRODUCTION

New York Regional Mormon Singles Halloween Dance by Elna Baker -- where the costumes are creative, the rules are strict, and the dating pool is deeply committed to not touching you.

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ELNA: **(Pg 12-13)** [That's right!] The dance rules. The most important one, announced over the pulpit on Sunday, is that there is to be no cross-dressing or wearing of masks. I understand the logic behind no cross-dressing, though I doubt that if a man were to dress like a woman at this function he would suddenly realize his true identity. But masks? Two: there is to be no inappropriate dancing or lascivious behavior. That's why there are too many lights overhead and only "safe" songs like "Cotton-eyed Joe" on the sound system. *(**dance and sing/hum a few lines from the song).* When slow songs do play people joke that you should be able to fit *Old Testament*, *New Testament*, *The Book of Mormon*, *Doctrine and Covenants*, and *Pearl of Great Price* between you and your partner. . . or you're dancing too close.

If it weren't already painfully obvious, these events are organized to facilitate marriage. How else would we Mormons meet, marry, then make more Mormons? (Take ***that***, Sally and your seashells on the seashore.) Contrary to popular belief, there are Mormons who live in New York City. I don't know how many of us there are all together, but there are probably 800 single Mormons and at least 20,000 former Mormons.

I moved to New York to go to NYU for acting *(strike a dramatic pose)* **(Pg 14-15)** My parents wanted me to go to BYU, Brigham Young University, in Provo, Utah. They were worried that if I didn't go to BYU, I'd stop being Mormon, and I wouldn't meet anyone to marry. Well, they were right about the second part. When I got my letter of acceptance to NYU, my mother was terrified, so she sat me down for a mother-daughter talk. *(they begin packing Elna's suitcase)*

MOTHER: *(nervously)* Elna, the first thing that will happen when you move to New York is, you might start to swear. And swearing will lead to drinking. And drinking will lead to doing drugs. *(beat)* And Elna, *(pursing her lips)* what would you do if a lesbian tried to make out with you? *(crosses her arms, waiting for an answer)*

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ELNA: *(holding back laughter)* I was used to her saying words like ***church calling*** and ***relief society***. Not the word ***lesbian***, let alone ***lesbian*** and ***make out*** in the same sentence. It was awesome!

If you followed my mother's logic, each step was a progression toward becoming more of a sinner. First I'd swear, then I'd drink, then I'd do drugs. By that point I was getting used to the narrative, so I assumed sex with men would be next. But no—my mother skipped that altogether and jumped to my becoming a lesbian. Did my mother honestly think that I had a better chance with a woman than a man? *(composing herself; to mother)* I'd say, 'No, thank you . . . lesbian.'

MOTHER: *(rolling her eyes)* There are these clubs in New York where men pay larger women to dance with very little clothing on; ***don't do that***.

ELNA: *(to audience)* Great, my mom thinks I'm moving to the big city to become a lesbian stripper. Apparently, when she told me I was "special," this is what she meant. **(Pg 16)** That's when my mother saw it, among my tightly folded clothes: a rainbow scarf. It reminded me of Punky Brewster in a retro eighties sort of way.

MOTHER: *(snatching it out)* You can't wear this in New York! Everyone will think that you're gay.

ELNA: *(to audience)* My mother thought gay people had a monopoly on rainbows. In my opinion rainbows are for everyone, like unicorns. *(to mother)* Mom, I'm not gay.

MOTHER: I know, but you should avoid the appearance.

ELNA: *(to audience)* I tried to get my scarf back. I explained how cold I would be without it. I even tried to usher her into this century by explaining that wearing rainbows didn't automatically mean a person was gay. The Lucky Charms leprechaun was not necessarily a homosexual. The Care Bear with the rainbow on his tummy did not have a life partner. He didn't even have genitals. Eventually my mom gave me money to buy a new scarf. But she was **not**, under any circumstances, going to let me take the rainbow scarf to New York City.

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(Pg 15) My father sat me down a few days later for another leaving-the-nest talk. His advice was a little different.

FATHER: Elna, never forget these three things. Number One: Never wear a dead man's socks. Number Two: Never let 'em see you sweat. And Number Three: Never touch a fat man's stomach.

ELNA: *(exaggerated confused look)* That was all the advice I was given before moving to New York City. **(Pg 17)** When I walked into my dorm room, the first thing I noticed was a big rainbow flag hanging on the wall. The only way it could have possibly gotten better would have been if my roommate walked in smoking a cigarette and offered to give me a lap dance. I'd never actually met a lesbian until I met Lisa. It turned out Lisa had never met a Mormon until she met me. And despite all the things we were supposed to be, we hit it off right from the start.

(Pg 18-19) I guess this probably isn't the kind of stuff most Mormons would even acknowledge. But then again, I've always been different from most Mormons. Mormonism can sound pretty farfetched: Joseph Smith digs up golden plates and translates them into a book, The Book of Mormon. This book ends up being a history of the ancestors of the Native Americans, who originated in Jerusalem and believed in Jesus. When you write it all out like that you can't help but reconsider. Once I tried explaining it to a friend. I went into all the things that I believed. I thought I was doing a good job explaining everything until he said . . .

FRIEND: So basically according to you, Pocahontas was actually a Jew?

ELNA: **(Pg 123-124)** *(distracted by events at the dance)* Ohhhh! It's time for the talent show!

RANDOM MALE: *(rapping with a microphone)* Hey brothers and sisters, Listen to me,
I'm talking to you religiously,
My Mormon Rap will make you see,
That I'm as funky as Donny and Marie.
Mormon, Mormon Rap, Do the Mo-mo-mo-mo- mormon Rap.
I'm a fine young man, I'm living clean,
Don't smoke, Don't drink, If you know what I mean.
Flipp'n, fetch'n, scruddle-dee-me,
Jiminy cricket, and fiddledy-dee!

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ELNA: *(clapping politely, then turns to the audience)* [Where were we? . . . Oh yes,] **(Pg 19)** The miracles one is expected to believe in the Mormon faith are no different from the miracles you are supposed to believe in any faith. My problem is I was always a skeptic.

When I was four and my mom first told me the story of Moses parting the Red Sea with his hands, I looked at her and said, "Yeah right, Mom." My mother tried to convince me that Moses had indeed parted a sea just by lifting his arms. I rolled my eyes and patted her on the knee like she was a crazy person.

By the age of six, I was already asking my mother, "When do we graduate from church?" To my dismay I was told that the word to describe being done with church was not "graduate" – it was ***death***.

And I wasn't exactly enthusiastic about getting baptized. Mormons are baptized at eight years old. According to my parents and teachers, when you were baptized you were washed clean. So why get baptized at eight? None of us had done anything. Why not wait until we were seventy? That way you could lead a fun life, do whatever you wanted to, and have a Get Out of Jail Free card at the end.

(Pg 21-22) When I was 19, I read The Book of Mormon cover-to-cover for the first time. And while I was reading it, I felt like I was leading a better life and making better choices. But [if] I'm being honest. I think most religious people experience just as much doubt as they do faith. And I don't think doubting makes you bad. I think it makes you smart. **(Pg 144)** If everyone based their faith on common sense no one would be religious—faith is totally illogical.

(Pg 22) A few Sundays ago, some idiot stood up in church and started talking about how we were having such a mild autumn. He went on and on about how pleasant the weather was and then jumped to,

CHURCH MAN: So really if you think about it, it's a sign that Jesus Christ [is] coming soon.

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ELNA: And so began my usual downward spiral: The weather is warm because of climate change ***not*** because Jesus is on his way. How can I belong to a church where people believe such crazy things? I mean, nowhere in The Book of Mormon does it say mild autumn equals Jesus, but technically I'm supposed to believe in the second coming. Do I? I don't know. How can I possibly sign my name to something I don't entirely agree with?

(distracted again) Oh, hold on. A guy, Dave, totally hot, just made eye contact with me. He's dressed as Paul Bunyan, which would be cool if 2 other guys hadn't also thought of it. Wait, I think he's walking in my direction. Oh, my gosh, he is. What do I do? Okay. Just play it cool. Show him your stinger. *(adjust slightly and wiggle stinger)*

DAVE: **(Pg 23)** How's it going?

ELNA: *(flirting awkwardly)* Fine. Where's Babe?*(Dave looks incredibly confused)* Paul Bunyan traveled with a blue ox.

DAVE: I'm not Paul Bunyan. *(annoyed)* I'm Brigham Young! *(struts off)*

ELNA: *(choking on a cookie and calling after him)* Sorry, the fake beard threw me off. *(to audience)* I should've stopped there, but instead I added . . . *(calling after Dave)* So the women who've been congregating around you all night, they weren't your multiple wives? *(to audience)* I thought this was pretty funny. Dave didn't even laugh. Mormons don't know how to laugh at themselves. *(beat)*

(Pg 25-26) After four years of being a Mormon in New York, I've become a reluctant spokesperson for my faith. I'm constantly answering questions or explaining my religion. Every question is about whether I'm a polygamist, whether I've had sex, whether I wear magic underwear, and whether I believe in dinosaurs. For the record: I'm ***not*** a polygamist, I have ***not*** had sex, I ***don't*** wear magic underwear, and I ***do*** believe in dinosaurs.

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[But] There are Mormon stereotypes: Mormons have big families; they're from Utah; they wear modest clothes; they're friendly, naive people; they have white teeth; and they're Republican. But that list only scratches the surface.

(Pg 29) I [just] am a Mormon in New York. A Mormon in New York seeking another Mormon in New York. Which brings me back to: The New York Regional Mormon Singles Halloween Dance. **(Pg 161)** [This is] the year I meet the Morman man of my dreams. *(digs down deep for courage . . .)* **(Pg 89)** Let's Dance! *(sing and do a few dance moves to the Macarena***)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
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MN State Qualifier

Party in the USA: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=M11SvDtPBhA

**** Cotton Eyed Joe Dance Moves: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ovq0YTMGk1A***

***** Macarena Dance Moves: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6LIkX0U6f5k***

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